

COVID-19 pandemic, climate change and Indigenous knowledges informing the future of social work

Qualitative Social Work
2025, Vol. 24(2-3) 301–320
© The Author(s) 2024



Article reuse guidelines:

sagepub.com/journals-permissions

DOI: 10.1177/14733250241300308

journals.sagepub.com/home/qsww



Mary Kate Dennis 

Faculty of Social Work, University of Manitoba, Winnipeg, MB, Canada

Finn McLafferty Bell

University of Michigan, Dearborn, MI, USA

Abstract

The COVID-19 pandemic revealed more fully social, economic, racial, and environmental disparities and offers a glimpse into the future. We recognize this moment as an opportunity to not only address the current pandemic, but also the climate crisis, which promises even more intense disruptions and disasters. This is not new for Indigenous people who have already experienced the end of their worlds through colonization. Indigenous people have adapted to change by relying on the knowledge of their lands which ensured their survival and will help them to prepare for climate change. Social work must seize this moment to address conditions by focusing on environmental and Indigenous ways of knowing to remain relevant as a positive force for social change. We identify four places to seek transformation in the 21st century: social work practice by moving towards anticolonial practice, the capitalist economy by moving to degrowth, hierarchical social welfare by promoting mutual aid, and the industrial food system by moving to food sovereignty. Through an exemplary case study, we illustrate how these approaches incorporate Indigenous knowledges and translate to social work practice. We explore the roles that social work can use to create a future that ensures justice, prevents harm and promotes a thriving world.

Keywords

Indigenous, environmental social work, critical theory

Corresponding author:

Mary Kate Dennis, Faculty of Social Work, University of Manitoba, Winnipeg, MB R3T 2N2, Canada.

Email: marykate.dennis@umanitoba.ca

Introduction

“When times are easy and there’s plenty to go around, individual species can go it alone. But when conditions are harsh and life is tenuous, it takes a team sworn to reciprocity to keep life going forward. In a world of scarcity, interconnection and mutual aid become critical for survival. So say the lichens...These ancients carry teachings in the ways that they live. They remind us of the enduring power that arises from mutualism, from the sharing of the gifts carried by each species. Balanced reciprocity has enabled them to flourish under the most stressful of conditions. Their success is measured not by consumption and growth, but by graceful longevity and simplicity, by persistence while the world changed around them. It is changing now.”

Robin Wall [Kimmerer \(2013, p. 272-275\)](#)

As Kimmerer identifies, the world is changing in dramatic and challenging ways. While the experience of the COVID-19 pandemic may be fading from memories, 1.2 million people have died from the disease in the United States alone ([CDC, 2024](#)). American Indian/Alaska Native, Native Hawaiian or other Pacific Islander, Black and Hispanic people living in the US were twice as likely to die from COVID-19 when compared to their White counterparts ([Hill and Artiga, 2022](#)). The social, economic, racial, and environmental disparities exacerbated by the pandemic reveal how unequally people are affected by crises. As [Roy \(2020\)](#) argued, “the pandemic is a portal,” meaning that it is both a glimpse into our future and a potential vehicle to change that future. We can examine this crisis as an opportunity to transform our social systems into ones that are just, sustainable, and resilient by embracing Indigenous knowledges. The COVID-19 pandemic lifted the veil on how untenable life is in a capitalist, colonized context and how we cannot escape our interdependence.

The climate crisis promises further harshening of conditions and tenuousness of life. The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) lays out the short-term, mid-term, and long-term risks that climate-induced ecological breakdown presents, which include death and destruction from extreme weather events, profound water shortages, and widespread food insecurity (2022). For Indigenous people, this is not new. American Indians have already survived an apocalypse and seen the end of their worlds ([Gross, 2016](#) in [Whyte, 2017](#)). This experience is shared by Indigenous people globally who experienced colonization, dispossession and assimilation tactics. As Indigenous people prepare for climate change, they return to the Indigenous knowledges of the lands and environment that have ensured their survival and adaptation over time and will prepare them for even more adaptation into the future ([Whyte, 2017](#)). A core principle of Indigenous knowledge is the interdependence of all living beings ([Cajete, 2000](#)). Social work will also have to adapt and respond as the effects of climate change become more catastrophic and Indigenous knowledges can inform these practices, but, to do so, the field needs to undergo a paradigm shift.

The growing focus on Indigenous ways of knowing within environmental social work presents important opportunities for social workers to respond to the ever more urgent

climate crisis (Ramsay and Boddy, 2017). However, it is not enough for a specific subfield of social work to integrate Indigenous knowledges within existing colonial paradigms in the field. Rather, in order to respond to the climate crisis, social work as a whole - including governing bodies, unions, educators and practitioners - needs to radically transform. To effectively do so, we must address the climate predicament at the root cause level, which includes colonialism and capitalism, and target specific leverage points “where a small shift in one thing can produce big changes in everything” (Meadows, 1999: p. 1). We identify four leverage points to target: social work practice (moving to anticolonial practice), the capitalist economy (moving to degrowth), hierarchical social welfare (moving to mutual aid), and the industrial food system (moving to food sovereignty). Each of these transformations represents a shift in paradigms - the hegemonic collective knowledge that undergirds a society. While paradigm shifts on a societal scale are difficult, they are the most impactful leverage points in terms of changing the system as a whole (Meadows, 1999). Further, these four areas have an outsized effect on how well social workers respond to the ravages of the climate crisis. Each of these paradigm shifts are based in Indigenous ways of knowing. Through an exemplary case example of the Sacred Roots program at the American Indian Health and Family Services (AIHFS) in Detroit, USA, we illustrate how these four approaches appear in social work practice. We discuss how an embrace of Indigenous ways of knowing and doing enriches and challenges the field, as well as roles that all social workers can take to support these paradigm shifts.

Author one is American Indian/Alaska Native living in Canada. Author two is a white settler of primarily Irish heritage living on Anishinaabe lands in the United States. We write specifically about the conditions on Turtle Island/North America and recognize that social work paradigms vary across the world, including within other colonized contexts.

Moving into the future: From COVID-19 to climate change

Lessons from the COVID-19 pandemic are relevant to the climate crisis. Climate change makes pandemics more likely, and the failure in the US to adequately respond to COVID-19 shows how utterly unprepared we are to deal with the kinds of disruptions and disasters that the climate crisis is currently causing and which are expected to only intensify (Horton, 2021). If social work is to actively shape a future dominated by climate catastrophe, we need to be realistic about how disruptive these changes are and embrace the transformations that are necessary to respond at the scale needed. We need to think in a much more expansive way and to recognize the limits of the field as it currently stands. The climate crisis clarifies that social work is not, and never will be, able to meet everyone's needs. Therefore, the crisis necessitates that we need to do our work differently. We need to actively address the root causes of the climate crisis, including capitalism and colonialism, within our practice and beyond (Bell et al., 2019).

In its 2022 report, the IPCC finally acknowledged that colonialism is both a driver of climate change and makes communities more vulnerable to its impacts (IPCC, 2022). However, the climate justice movement has known this for decades. At COP 26, the Brazilian Indigenous activist Taily Terena argued that “Colonialism caused climate

change. Our rights and traditional knowledge are the solution.” (Funes, 2022, n.p.). However, it is not just colonialism that is driving climate change, but also its intertwined economic system, capitalism which is dependent on destruction of the environment for its functioning (Ghosh, 2021; Moore, 2017). These interconnecting systems are the root causes of the climate predicament, and attempts to address climate change without getting at the roots will fail (Táíwò, 2022).

Further, the COVID-19 pandemic shows us how system failures are likely to only intensify and worsen in the climate crisis. This moment is an inflection point in thinking about the future of social work, as new possibilities are opening up that would have seemed unimaginable even just a short time ago, and we are facing non-linear change that challenges existing paradigms (Gorbis, 2019). Social workers can learn from what people on the ground are doing to respond to this pandemic as well as what communities have long been doing to protect and care for each other (Bell et al., 2019). Social work scholarship and training is too often disconnected from what social workers and other community workers are already doing on the ground (Maylea, 2020). Indigenous people have long been doing the work to prevent climate catastrophe (Dennis and Bell, 2020). The field needs to support these efforts, given that climate change will dominate every practice area in the future.

With the rise of environmental social work, the field is increasingly acknowledging the climate crisis (Krings et al., 2020). However, Kenkel (2020) argues that all social workers have a moral duty to take the risks of climate change seriously, including the risk of societal breakdown co-occurring with ecological breakdown. If the field does not evolve and adapt to meet this crisis, social workers will be pulled into ever more punitive, neoliberal modes of practice in a world of increasing scarcity (Kenkel, 2020). Nonetheless, we know that there is another way. The profession of social work is at a critical juncture to realign our practice with our values and ethics to prepare for the future, as we offer suggestions on in later sections. Recognizing this moment for the transformative opportunity that it is - in both learning the lessons from the recent pandemic and in addressing the climate crisis - represents an opportunity to make social work a force for lasting social change. Moving into an uncertain future, we need the field to dedicate our particular skill sets to meeting the intense challenges that the 21st century brings. The stakes could not be higher. As UN Secretary-General, António Guterres (2020, n.p.) proclaimed,

The decisions we make now will determine the course of the next 30 years and beyond: [global greenhouse gas] emissions must fall by half by 2030 and reach net-zero emissions no later than 2050 to reach the 1.5 C goal. Science is clear: if we fail to meet these goals, the disruption to economies, societies and people caused by COVID-19 will pale in comparison to what the climate crisis holds in store.

Given how much worse the expected disruption from climate change is compared to what we experienced in the COVID-19 pandemic, in looking to the future, social workers and social work institutions need to center the climate crisis from an anticolonial lens.

From a settler social work to anticolonial practice

In the US, there is an absence of discussion on how settler colonialism has shaped the foundation of US history and identity, as well as current social and cultural conditions. Settler colonialism is “characterized by specific ways of thinking about heritage, belonging, race and difference, and power” (Wolfe in Battell Lowman and Barker, 2016: p. 25). Inherent to settler colonialism is the erasure of Indigenous peoples and the creation of a structure in which they and others are seen as inferior to white, European settlers. As a result, there has been a suppression and denial of Indigenous knowledges and history because such concepts were replaced with European patriarchal, individualist perspectives focused on private land ownership in US society (Battell Lowman and Barker, 2016; Hart, 2009; Simpson, 2004). This rupture enabled the climate crisis by breaking the relationships and responsibilities held between humans, the land, plants, and non-human animals (Kimmerer, 2013; Táíwò, 2022).

US-based social work, on the whole, has not engaged in a process of recognizing settler colonialism and acknowledging social work’s role in upholding colonial social structures (Dennis and Robin, 2020; Powers et al., 2019). Social work is deeply rooted in European settler colonialism in prioritizing individualism and self-efficacy (Hart, 2009; Powers et al., 2019). In North America, social work privileges western therapeutic approaches and is skeptical of Indigenous methods of healing and knowledge, including a more collective consciousness of health and well-being (Hart, 2009). Social work must examine our education and practice models in order to incorporate knowledges and healing beyond biomedical and individualist notions. This could partially be achieved by creating specific practice standards, advocating for reconciliation with Indigenous communities with adherence to the recommendations and outcomes by moving beyond tokenistic efforts and moving more deeply to commit to reorienting social work practice. Looking towards other countries (e.g. New Zealand) that have successfully incorporated Indigenous knowledges and ways of being into practice is imperative for the US to address in practice standards (Beddoe, 2018; McNabb, 2019). There are likely practices on the ground that have not been featured and seen as exemplary for practicing with Indigenous people and communities Embracing a social, political, and cultural stance of anticolonialism through resistance to colonial and capitalistic structures is a way to address the root causes of the climate crisis, and repair and prevent harm.

Anticolonialism recognizes that colonialism is imposed and dominating (Hart, 2009). It includes political, social, and cultural resistance to colonial frameworks (Hart, 2009; Smith, 1999). Anticolonial practice involves questioning “institutional power and privilege and the rationale for dominance, and acknowledg[ing] the intertwining role of state, societal and institutional structures...in producing and reproducing inequalities,” which fits with social work values related to social justice and protecting vulnerable populations (Hart, 2009: p. 30). The US has not conducted a Truth and Reconciliation process to explore how the subjugation of racialized people was essential in establishing the political, economic, legal, and social structures of what became the US. Nor has the US addressed the ongoing effects of colonization and enslavement (Táíwò, 2022). COVID-19 revealed more explicitly how the colonial legacy of racial disparities and

injustices continues (Lakhani, 2021). Racist killings of Indigenous and Black people continued during the pandemic, which then interrupted the ways in which people were able to gather and grieve collectively (Dennis, 2021). The future of social work should include a full engagement with anticolonial perspectives by resisting dominant colonial ideologies that oppress racialized people. Social work can enact this paradigm shift by engaging in a critical analysis of colonialism within our profession and the ways in which social work supports and upholds colonial frameworks, but this must be followed by concrete action (Dennis and Robin, 2020).

The recovery of Indigenous and other non-western knowledges is an essential strategy for anticolonialism (Simpson, 2004). In order to do so, a deconstruction of colonial thinking must happen along with a critical recognition that colonialism influences the construction of Indigenous and non-western knowledges (Hart, 2009). Anticolonial practice creates spaces for recovery of Indigenous knowledge systems and establishes local control over territories, protection of lands from destruction, and creation of educational opportunities that are rooted in Indigenous traditions (Simpson, 2004; Hart, 2009). Additionally, social work practice standards could formalize these roles and responsibilities for social work practitioners and educators. We can look to other countries, such as New Zealand which has effectively incorporated Māori ways of knowing into their practice standards (Beddoe, 2018; McNabb, 2019). Indigenous people sustain practices and values in part through frontline environmental activism against corporate exploitation and climate change (Dennis and Bell, 2020). Social workers can take actions to enact an anticolonial perspective by: supporting communities in taking collective action, helping to unify and mobilize allies of the anticolonial movement, and overtly and aggressively challenging the injustices of colonial state authority (Hart, 2009). This is timely work. Whyte (2017) argues that Indigenous people have already endured many of the expected impacts of climate change during colonization by being displaced and reduced to small reservations and having the lands, waters, and food sources destroyed, as well as the many cultural changes of the assimilation tactics of boarding schools, patriarchy and the imposition of corporate government structures incentivizing extractive industries. Learning from those who have already survived the impacts of epochal changes and having a reparative process for the harm that has happened and continues to happen is an essential task in responding to the root causes of the climate crisis. There are many paths and methodologies to achieve anticolonialism that can be taken by different communities and groups. Many of the underlying values and ethics of social work focused on working for social justice and to protect vulnerable populations speak to an orientation that would support anticolonialism; however, actively adopting anticolonial practice is sorely needed for the future of social work.

From a capitalist economy to degrowth

The fossil fuel era has been a unique time of hyper-growth, but as these fuels took millennia to develop and are by definition not renewable, the fossil fuel era itself will come to an end (Polack et al., 2008). However, the dominant economic paradigm focused on the need for constant growth was developed with the assumption that fossil fuels would

remain abundant and burnable, or, more recently that technological advances would allow people to maintain high consumer lifestyles without fossil fuels forever (Holmgren, 2009). Neither of these assumptions appear to be true. Consequently, degrowth—a set of theories and a movement, coming out of political ecology, ecological economics, and environmental justice, that critiques the possibility of perpetual economic growth—has gained traction in recent years (Nugent, 2021; Powers et al., 2019). However, the devastating economic consequences of the COVID-19 pandemic make the distinction between intentional and unintentional degrowth important (FaDa, 2020). As we saw in the US as the stock market boomed while low-wage workers suffered immeasurably during the pandemic, unintentional degrowth hits people incredibly unequally, while intentional degrowth is premised on making society and the economy more equitable (Osaka, 2020). The climate crisis will cause significantly more disruption than the COVID-19 pandemic has (Guterres, 2020), which is why planning for intentional degrowth is important, rather than letting unintentional degrowth caused by cascading crises take hold.

The COVID-19 pandemic made the failures of capitalism in meeting human needs clearer. Early in the pandemic, the brittleness of a capitalist system motivated by maximizing profits for shareholders was seen in how just-in-time deliveries produced scarcity of essential goods from personal protective equipment to toilet paper (Moody, 2020). Further, the need for perpetual growth within a capitalist economy created a life and death dilemma from the household level to the macroeconomic level in which workers, business owners, and policymakers had to choose between risking exposure to a life-threatening global pandemic or risking economic ruin (Powell, 2020).

While the COVID-19 pandemic showed capitalism's inability to adequately meet human needs, climate change magnifies capitalist failure on multiple fronts. In addition to the inability to meet human needs in both regular times and times of crisis and disaster, capitalist economies do not have a way to include "externalities" such as the destruction of the planet on which we all depend (Meadows et al., 2004; Osaka, 2020). Although a robust social welfare system in capitalist economies may seem to be the solution to meeting human needs, countries that have such a system are still unable to make their welfare systems sustainable in a growth-dependent economy (Hirvilammi and Koch, 2020). To put it simply, a system predicated on perpetual growth is incompatible with the natural limits of a planet with finite resources (Meadows et al., 2004).

Before the advent of a modern capitalist system, the "economy" was based on social relationships of reciprocity (Kimmerer, 2003; Polanyi, 2001). That is, people had relationships with others in their community in which they shared and traded essential goods and services. Where such arrangements differ most dramatically from the market economy that we know today is that there was no such thing as an economy outside of those social relationships (Polanyi, 2001). When the rise of a market economy first developed in Europe, peasants revolted against the idea that their neighbors could set grain prices so high that they would literally starve to death (Thompson, 2001). That economic activity could be dictated by abstract principles of profit maximization rather than ensuring the community's collective survival was unfathomable (Polanyi, 2001; Thompson, 2001).

When Europeans exported this market economy as a part of their colonization of North America, it was not just the subsumption of social relationships that was unthinkable by

Indigenous peoples, given the violent process of colonization (Simpson, 2004). Rather, the fact that there was no room for relationship with the Earth itself and all of the species that Indigenous peoples recognized as relations with whom they held reciprocal responsibilities was a new and devastating consequence of colonization and the imposition of market-based economies on the “New World” (Dennis and Bell, 2020). Where colonial market-based economies view the natural world as containing resources to be extracted for profit, Indigenous worldviews see animals, plants, rocks, and water as offering their own specific gifts to the web of life (Kimmerer, 2003; LaDuke, 1999).

Degrowth is a diverse, multi-faceted movement that is broadly relevant to social work moving into the future. In forming the concept of doughnut economics, Raworth (2017) argues that the challenges of the 21st century necessitate letting go of growth as a measure of economic success, in favor of keeping economic activity within a safe and just doughnut that prioritizes meeting human needs while protecting the environment. Thus, on a number of fronts, such as water and biodiversity loss, Raworth (2017) measures whether societies are meeting the social foundation essential to a just economy, which represents the inner ring of the doughnut, and whether we are staying beneath the ecological ceiling that signifies safe functioning, which represents the outer ring of the doughnut.

Doughnut economics is particularly relevant to social workers in the 21st century for a number of reasons. First, doughnut economics focuses on areas social work has long prioritized—both meeting human needs and seeking justice—but doughnut economics also incorporates protecting the natural world in a way that social work has largely neglected in contrast to Indigenous ways of knowing and being (Dennis and Bell, 2020). Second, doughnut economics prioritizes the care work that many social workers do, which is devalued in the capitalist economy (Raworth, 2017). Third, doughnut economics challenges the mechanistic theoretical origins of classical economic theory that undergird settler colonial public policy (Raworth, 2017). Rather, Raworth (2017) argues that an embrace of complexity and systems thinking is needed both in economics and in policy proposals. Macro social workers, who operate in the realms of community development, organizing, policy, and evaluation, are uniquely situated to meet this need. Finally, as we can see in efforts underway in Amsterdam, doughnut economics can be actualized on a relatively small scale, such as including the true costs of products’ environmental and social impacts into their price (Nugent, 2021).

Nonetheless, the degrowth movement has been criticized for taking an ahistorical perspective that discounts the impact of colonization in building the global economy. In particular, Richter (2019) argues that “an analysis of how the legacies of colonialism and coloniality have come to shape our current world positions ecological debt and environmental justice (EJ) at the heart of the degrowth discourse” (p. 5-6). In order to truly shift the paradigm, focusing on repairing past harm is essential, as is changing the discourse around nature away from thinking of materials or resources to be used/exploited to nature (including humans) as a “living world” wherein every being has rights, responsibilities, and agency (Richter, 2019: p. 12). To understand what this looks like in practice Richter (2019) argues that we should examine “Qualitative work with those who are already living local and culturally specific versions of degrowth” (p. 9) such as our

case study in Detroit, an intervention that helps people to meet their basic needs in a culturally and geographically traditional way while improving their environment.

From a hierarchical social welfare system to mutual aid

The concept of deserving and undeserving poor is the organizing principle of the US social welfare system, which turns a social problem, poverty, into an individual problem, perversity (Somers and Block, 2005). By blaming the individual for the social problem that they are victim of, the solutions target the behavior and the morality of the individual in racialized and gendered ways, rather than targeting the root causes of the social problem (Spade, 2020; Fraser and Gordon, 1994). Thus, rather than ensuring that everyone has a safe and decent place to live in the US, unhoused people themselves are criminalized by laws that prohibit daily acts of survival, such as sleeping, covering oneself, urinating, and sitting, when they happen in public (Bell, 2014). Rather than providing free and abundant direct material assistance to poor families, receiving welfare in the US is so stigmatized and laden with difficult conditions that many families do everything that they can to avoid it, if it is even a possibility for them (Spade, 2020; Edin and Schaefer, 2015). The embeddedness of the idea of perversity (Somers and Block, 2005) within social welfare results in systems that co-opt many well-intentioned social workers into reproducing the unequal status quo, despite often entering the field with the explicit desire to upend social injustice (Kivel, 2007).

Mutual aid is prevalent within anarchist theory and disavows the charity model in which those in need must be recognized as deserving of help, in favor of practicing solidarity with all people and dismantling oppression (Izlar, 2019). Rather than creating a hierarchy of professional helpers funded by a donor class that is largely responsible for the conditions that create the needs to begin with, mutual aid happens via horizontal networks in which people give what they can and get what they need (Bell, 2021; Izlar, 2019). This form of helping—and much of anarchist thought—has North American Indigenous roots (Nowell, 2020) and is a return to the recognition that each species has special gifts to give and that resilience comes from mutualism (Kimmerer, 2003, 2013).

Black, Indigenous, and people of color (BIPOC) communities in the US have long practiced mutual aid both as a part of enduring culture and because BIPOC communities have been explicitly and implicitly excluded from state welfare benefits (Reid-Merritt, 2010). For these communities, the relationship with the state was more likely to be as targets of state control, coercion, and violence (Samudzi and Anderson, 2018). To put it plainly, many BIPOC communities have never experienced governmental social welfare schemes as a source of help, but rather have developed (and continued) ways of helping each other - mutual aid - in the absence of these official programs.

During the COVID-19 pandemic, mutual aid projects received a groundswell of interest, as they have shown promise in meeting people's basic survival needs where traditional social welfare systems and markets failed (Sitrin and Colectiva Sembrar, 2020). In the early months of COVID-19, a wide spectrum of people engaged in this work, and their understanding of mutual aid varied considerably. While more privileged people tended to see mutual aid as a short-term response to the COVID-19 crisis which was

similar to traditional aid and could work in tandem with the government, socially marginalized people were more likely to see mutual aid as a source of ongoing support that was explicitly different from traditional aid and a necessary alternative to the government (Littman et al., 2023). Nonetheless, some common values undergirded mutual aid practice during this time, including: reciprocity, shared humanity, and community-driven care and redistribution of resources (Littman et al., 2021). The experience of the pandemic in the US - wherein the most vulnerable people were left to their fates which resulted in further spread of the disease - made clear how short-sighted abandoning the collective in favor of an individualist approach to care is, with explicit calls to decolonize community care (Begay, 2020). As we move into an even more uncertain era of climate crisis, the need for robust, flexible ways to care for each other becomes all the more important.

However, social work in the US has had a conflictual relationship with mutual aid. On the level of the individual social work practitioner, mutual aid can be perplexing (Bell, 2021). Our field is one that defines us as professional helpers. If mutual aid demands that we break down categories of helpers and helpees, instead embracing that we all give what we can and take what we need, this can prompt an identity crisis for social workers. Nonetheless, the discomfort with mutual aid in social work goes much deeper than individual workers.

US-based social work has had a fraught relationship with radical political traditions more broadly, with intense struggles for and delegitimization of communism, socialism, and anarchism occurring in the mid-twentieth century (Reisch and Andrews, 2002). These struggles continue to this day although they are now more likely framed around abolition (Baines, 2021), mutual aid (Izlar, 2019), and decolonization (McCleary and Simard, 2021). Mutual aid is based in anti-state and anti-authoritarian principles, which presents another tension for social work as the field is deeply embedded within the state (Baines, 2021) and the professionalization of social work was in part about establishing authority at the expense of solidarity (Izlar, 2019). Finally, embracing mutual aid requires a reckoning with the whitewashing of social welfare history more broadly (McCleary and Simard, 2021; Wright et al., 2021) because BIPOC social workers have long operated under collectivist principles against state-based coercion.

All of this is not to say that social work can not or should not embrace mutual aid, especially moving into an even more uncertain future under climate change. Rather, we argue that changing our paradigm to a solidarity model of social welfare could not be more important at this time of history. A common refrain in social work education is that we want to “work ourselves out of a job.” This is often framed in terms of individual clients achieving well-being and self-actualization. However, given that a wide-scale embrace of mutual aid requires us to simultaneously confront colonialism, racism, capitalism, and authoritarianism, working ourselves out of a job as professional helpers is not a bad thing. This is especially true in this time of omnicrisis (Nissen and Scheyett, 2022). Social workers, too, are and will be in need of help. Rather than reacting to the current and coming crises in increasingly punitive ways (Kenkel, 2020), building a culture of solidarity and mutual aid allows social workers to build a prefigurative politics, creating the world that we want to live in in the here and now (Raekstad, 2018).

From an industrial food system to food sovereignty

Indigenous peoples, peasants, small-scale farmers, and farm workers organized the global food sovereignty movement, La Via Campesina (Desmarais, 2007; Wittman et al., 2010). After experiencing the devastating effects of international agricultural policies of the 1980s and 1990s, La Via Campesina effectively placed food sovereignty on local, national, and international agendas and into international discourse. This movement challenged the neoliberal, corporate-led, industrial model of agriculture which leads to crises that result in “rural exodus from the countryside, disempowerment of small-scale farming, human rights abuses and environmental degradation” (Desmarais, 2015: p. 154; Wittman et al., 2010). Food sovereignty is rooted in agrarian reform to ensure that people have the right to grow their own food in ways that are in-line with cultural values and care for the environment (Desmarais, 2003; Patel, 2009). The core of food sovereignty is challenging deep inequalities of power and promoting a radical egalitarianism where the capacity to shape food policy can be exercised by everyone at all levels (Patel, 2009). Food sovereignty goes further than food security, in that it considers the producers of the food and the environment as well as asserting that food is a human right (Desmarais, 2015). Food security focuses on an individual’s access to food. Food security is defined as “when all people, at all times, have physical and economic access to sufficient safe and nutritious food that meets their dietary needs and food preferences for an active and healthy life” (World Bank, nd), or simply, when people “do not have enough food to eat and they are not sure when their next meal might be” (Feeding America, 2024).

Communities, farmers, activists, and scholars have taken up food sovereignty as a space to develop alternative visions of food and agriculture (Desmarais, 2015). As a result, food sovereignty has become a term that is hard to define as it encompasses complex ideas, theories, and practices (Wittman et al., 2010). The use of food sovereignty as a concept has expanded and has overlapping definitions, since woven into food sovereignty is the notion that peoples’ right to shape food policy would also include exploring and expanding the political philosophy behind the term (Patel, 2009). As Desmarais (2015) states, “whether is it called an idea, concept, framework, mobilizing tactic, counter narrative, countermovement, political project, campaign, process, vision, or even a living organism, food sovereignty has captured the hearts and minds of many who struggle for social change” (p. 156). It should be noted that the term food justice has been more frequently used in the global North and represents similar philosophical views and practices as food sovereignty (See Cadieux and Slocum, 2015 for the lineage and differences between these terms).

In social work practice, food has been a tool for intervention and community development (Jacobson, 2007; Turje, 2012). Despite these efforts, there have been criticisms and calls for social work to address more fully food insecurity (Burgess and Shier, 2018; Libal et al., 2014), food justice, and food sovereignty (Dennis and Robin, 2020). When social work has supported food-related issues it was through a food insecurity lens of access to healthy foods through food banks and community gardens (Dennis and Robin, 2020). Historically, the US-based National Association of Social Work (NASW), social work educators and practitioners have not fully or holistically addressed issues related to

hunger or the profession's complicity in food insecurity in Indigenous populations (Libal et al., 2014; Dennis and Robin, 2020). The NASW has not visibly advocated for federal or state food programs (Libal et al., 2014). Social work practitioners and the national social work organizations should be engaged in policy making around food security funding and interventions (Libal et al., 2014).

With food insecurity as a major social and public health issue of the 21st century, it is imperative that social workers move beyond charitable food programs and engage more fully in supporting food sovereignty in communities, scholarship, and practice (Dennis and Robin, 2020; Turje, 2012). COVID-19 and rising inflation revealed the fragility of the industrial food system, as well as the reliance on charitable food programs to fill in gaps and the need for more reliable sources of food (Bell, 2021). Social work should move towards a food sovereignty framework that addresses and questions the deeper, systemic effects of neoliberalism, colonization, and racism as well as other inequalities that are used as tools of oppression. Using a food sovereignty lens reveals that food insecurity in the global North is connected to these systems of oppression (Burgess and Shier, 2018; Dennis and Robin, 2020). Turje (2012) encourages social workers to be mindful of reinforcing notions of neoliberal food systems such as focusing on individualism instead of systemic issues related to food. Scholars critique the social work profession's silence on issues related to food security outside of economic crises and call for social work to place hunger as a critical social issue worthy of attention (Libal et al., 2014; Dennis and Robin, 2020).

This is particularly important in the 21st century. New research shows that climate models significantly underestimated the risk of concurrent weather extremes causing crop failures in multiple major crop producing regions thereby imperiling global food security (Cornhuber et al., 2023). As the disruptive effects of climate change are realized, a locally controlled food system will be essential for reliable food access (Newell et al., 2022). Moreover, given the central role food has in regard to health and well-being, social workers should intervene on food and hunger related issues on multiple levels (Burgess and Shier, 2018), and we argue this can be done through integrating food sovereignty into social work education and practice. Participating in policy development in national social work organizations, municipal, state and federal levels can shift away from the large corporate food system to a more local and self-sufficient community-level food system. As evidenced by the following case example, communities and organizations are creating local, culturally informed food sovereignty practices. Individuals and groups are supported in learning hands-on skills in growing and preparing food. More of these efforts should be highlighted and gathered for best practices.

Case example: Sacred Roots at American Indian health & Family Services (AIHFS)

The land now known as Detroit, Michigan is named Waawiyatanong in Anishinaabemowin, meaning "where the water goes around" (Castañeda López, 2019). This is the

land of the Anishinaabe or Three Fires people, the Ojibwe, Odawa, and Potawatomi. Anishinaabemowin - the language of the Anishinaabe - does not differentiate nouns by gender as many Latin-based languages do, but rather differentiates them by whether they are animate (trees, water, plants, and more are recognized as having life and spirit) or inanimate (manmade) (Cosme, 2020). These differing worldviews give insight into the connections between colonization and the climate crisis - "this is how we got to 410 ppm carbon in the atmosphere: a society that commodifies and destroys the sacred, worshipping the inanimate" (Cosme, 2020, n.p.). While the environmental impacts of Detroit's industrial legacy continue to do harm to the majority BIPOC city, the Anishinaabe lived in harmony with the more-than-human world on this land for millennia prior to colonization. Urban Native people in Detroit have used reclamation of Indigenous foodways as a form of resurgence, at times being targeted by state authorities for doing so, such as when a ceremony opening the collective work to gather maple syrup was broken up by the Detroit police (Maples, 2022). Nonetheless, the Sacred Roots food sovereignty program at AIHFS in Detroit, developed by Rosebud Bear Schneider and Shiloh Maples, exemplifies the role that social work practitioners can play in advancing paradigm shifts on all four sites for transformation. While Sacred Roots focuses explicitly on food sovereignty, by using social work best practices for working with communities, in this case urban Indigenous communities, the program also incorporated degrowth, mutual aid, and anticolonial practice into its development.

In thinking about food sovereignty, AIHFS felt that it was important to first consider the wisdom and practices of elders, and to build on that rather than trying to create something brand new. This process allowed for the creation of a program that addressed, "the real need for community spaces [where Indigenous people] support one another in healing around food" (Rosebud Bear Schneider, personal communication). Staff had the community envision what a healthy food system could look like, with a focus on cultural ways of relating to food. They invited people to be a part of the steering committee to come up with an action plan, including 5-6 different strategies that they could take. The steering committee members then voted on the most important strategies. Staff facilitated these discussions and decision-making processes, but the community members were in charge. This was transformative for many of the community members involved as it changed them from being positioned and identified as service users to community leaders. Community members sometimes resisted this transformation, but Schneider and Maples worked to continually put decision-making power back into the hands of community members. There was reciprocal learning where the community and the staff were sharing knowledge and learning together. The community came up with the name Sacred Roots and decided that they would like to focus their efforts on opening a communal kitchen and a seed library that centers Indigenous heirloom varieties. The community identified the kitchen and seed library as essential aspects of what a healthy food system would look like to them. From an Indigenous perspective, heirloom seeds are "witnesses to the past" that "hold cultural value and cultural memory that is a vital part of traditional culture and history" (White in LaDuke, nd, p. 17).

For people who are interested in starting food sovereignty initiatives in their own communities or organizations, Maples, a social worker, had this advice:

Slow, deliberate foundational work is really important because otherwise you could end up doing stuff that doesn't resonate with community members and doesn't address what they see as the root causes of injustice. It is really important to be intentional from the very beginning to make sure that your values are being actualized. Start small and focus on building relationships and building capacity (personal communication).

Maples' advice is simple yet encapsulates core wisdom of effective social work practice and marks a path forward to achieving transformation. Understanding what these initiatives look like within communities is vital because Indigenous ways of knowing and doing, while containing common themes, are culturally and geographically specific.

Social work policy and practice Implications

While Sacred Roots explicitly focuses on food sovereignty, it also incorporates degrowth, mutual aid, and anticolonial practice, preparing it well to effectively respond to the COVID-19 pandemic and the climate crisis. In regards to degrowth, the Sacred Roots program's activities help community members to address hunger, nutritional deficiencies, and oppression of Indigenous communities, while doing so in a non-capitalist manner that regenerates land rather than degrading it and acknowledges the interdependency of the living world (Richter, 2019). In doing so, the program operates within the doughnut economics safe and just zone (Raworth, 2017). In encouraging the steering committee to see themselves not as service recipients but rather as comrades in shaping an effort by and for their own urban Indigenous communities, AIHFS was able to build solidarity rather than offering charity, making this an example of mutual aid. Finally, by recovering Indigenous knowledges and practices in both how to grow and prepare food and how to relate to one another, the Sacred Roots program shows how social work can be practiced from an anticolonial perspective.

While the sites of transformation that we argue social workers need to pursue in the 21st century may be new concepts to some readers, as we have shown in our case example, the skill sets needed for these transformations are ones that social work educators have long sought to cultivate in their students (Fook and Jatlow, 2024). As Indigenous social workers and community workers, the Sacred Roots staff took a very particular approach to anti-colonial practice as members of the community they are working with. However, anti-colonial practice is analogous to antiracist practice in that all social workers can and should take an active stance against settler colonialism. Just as there is no such thing as being "not racist," there is no way to be neutral when it comes to settler colonialism (Kendi, 2019). How this looks in practice will vary, but could include: working alongside Indigenous and other communities of color to reframe the colonial experience, taking responsibility for one's own role in colonialism and taking actions to eradicate oppression, learning Indigenous ways of healing, and supporting efforts to center non-western knowledges.

Part of this also includes mutual aid, a more collective approach to helping and sharing of resources. In embracing mutual aid, social workers can help communities in meeting

their needs, horizontally rather than hierarchically, which privileges local knowledge and resources. Through mutual aid, AIHFS created an environment where staff and participants were sharing and learning together, creating networks of knowledge. They empowered each other to participate in mutual aid and food sovereignty through sharing practices of traditional foodways: growing, food preparation, seed saving, foraging, hunting and fishing. Further, mutual aid, anticolonial practice, and food sovereignty work synergistically with disavowing growth as the measure of success, in that they all help communities to focus their activities within the safe and just zone that improves people's lives while also protecting the environment. All four of these transformations have their roots in traditional Indigenous ways of knowing and being. Social work education can help to realize these necessary transformations by acknowledging the reality of settler colonialism, including Indigenous peoples' contributions, and by supporting, but not appropriating, Indigenous knowledges and practices.

Conclusion

The field of social work is at a critical juncture where the COVID-19 pandemic and the climate crisis are revealing systemic failures in the US. Having such clarity about what is not working and what is likely to only get worse as we face more severe disruptions and disasters in a changing climate (Kenkel, 2020), brings an opportunity to make transformative change. This is the time for the social work profession to ensure its relevance to the historic moment that we are facing, by shifting our existing paradigms to embrace anticolonial practice, degrowth, mutual aid, and food sovereignty. To illustrate what it looks like in practice to meet this historic moment, we examined an Indigenous food sovereignty program that precedes the pandemic but is increasingly relevant for the challenges that we face in the 21st century. The Sacred Roots program shows how embodying social work's best practice principles can help in advancing the transformative change that we need to effectively confront, not only the lasting effects of the COVID-19 pandemic, but also the looming climate crisis. Ultimately, governing bodies and practice standards throughout the social work field need to embrace these paradigm shifts; however, as Schneider and Maples exemplify, individual social workers and educators need not wait for institutional change to embrace shifts within their own scope of practice. While such transformative change may seem unthinkable, each of these principles are based on how social and economic systems functioned prior to capitalism and colonization in the US. In other words, we know that the future that we want is possible because we can see it when we look to the past. By being realistic and truthful about how the social work field developed into what it is today, we can transform the field into what we need it to be in the future, prioritizing Indigenous ways of knowing and being.

Declaration of conflicting interests

The author(s) declared no potential conflicts of interest with respect to the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

Funding

The author(s) received no financial support for the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

ORCID iD

Mary Kate Dennis  <https://orcid.org/0000-0002-0311-6274>

References

- Baines D (2021) Soft cops or social justice activists: social work's relationship to the state in the context of BLM and neoliberalism. *British Journal of Social Work* 52(5): 2984–3002.
- Battell Lowman E and Barker A (2016) *Settler: Identity and Colonialism in 21st Century Canada*. Melbourne: Fernwood.
- Beddoe L (2018) Social work education in Aotearoa New Zealand: building a profession. *Practice* 30(4): 305–320.
- Begay J (2020) Decolonizing community care in response to COVID-19. <https://ndncollective.org/indigenizing-and-decolonizing-community-care-in-response-to-covid-19/>.
- Bell S (2014) A conversation between Noel Timms and a US social work practitioner, nascent sociologist. *Qualitative Social Work* 13(6): 772–779.
- Bell FM (2021) Amplified injustices and mutual aid in the COVID-19 pandemic. *Qualitative Social Work* 20(1-2): 410–415.
- Bell FM, Dennis MK and Krings A (2019) Collective survival strategies and anti-colonial practice in ecosocial work. *Journal of Community Practice* 27: 279–295.
- Burgess D and Shier ML (2018) Food insecurity and social work: a comprehensive literature review. *International Social Work* 61(6): 826–842.
- Cadieux KV and Slocum R (2015) What does it mean to do food justice? *Journal of Political Ecology* 22: 1–26.
- Cajete G (2000) *Native Science: Natural Laws of Interdependence*. Santa Fe: Clear Light Publishers.
- Castañeda López R (2019) Resolution in support of recognizing Detroit's original name on indigenous people's day. *City of Detroit*. <https://detroitmi.gov/document/2019-09-26-resolution-renaming-detroit-original-name-indigenous-peoples-day>.
- Centers for Disease Control and Prevention [CDC] (2024) COVID data tracker. Retrieved from. https://covid.cdc.gov/covid-data-tracker/#maps_deaths-total.
- Cornhuber K, Lesk C, Schleussner CF, et al. (2023) Risks of synchronized low yields are underestimated in climate and crop model projections. *Nature Communications*, 14: 3528. DOI: [10.1038/s41467-023-38906-7](https://doi.org/10.1038/s41467-023-38906-7).
- Cosme A (2020) Waawiyatanong: A Detroit land acknowledgement. *Geez Magazine*. <https://geezmagazine.org/magazine/article/waawiyatanong-land-acknowledgement>.
- Dennis MK (2021) Collecting grief: Indigenous peoples, deaths by police and a global pandemic. *Qualitative Social Work* 20(1-2): 149–155.
- Dennis MK and Bell FM (2020) Indigenous women, water protectors, and reciprocal responsibilities. *Social Work* 65: 1–9. DOI: [10.1093/sw/swaa033](https://doi.org/10.1093/sw/swaa033).

- Dennis MK and Robin T (2020) Healthy on our own terms: indigenous wellbeing and the colonized food system. *Journal of Critical Dietetics* 5(1): 4–11.
- Desmarais AA (2003) The via campesina: peasant women at the frontiers of food sovereignty. *Canadian Woman Studies* 23(1): 140–145.
- Desmarais AA (2007) *La Via Campesina: Globalization and the Power of Peasants*. Melbourne: Fernwood.
- Desmarais A (2015) FS - the gift of food sovereignty. *Canadian Food Studies* 2(2): 154–163.
- Edin KJ and Schaefer HL (2015) *\$2 a day: living on almost nothing in America*. Boston: Houghton Mifflin Harcourt.
- Feeding America (2024) Hunger in America. <https://www.feedingamerica.org/hunger-in-america/food-insecurity>.
- Feminisms and Degrowth Alliance (FaDA) (2020) Collaborative feminist degrowth: pandemic as an opening for care-full radical transformation. *Resilience.org*. <https://www.resilience.org/stories/2020-05-08/collaborative-feminist-degrowth-pandemic-as-an-opening-for-a-care-full-radical-transformation/>.
- Fook J and Jatlow D (2024) *Transformative Social Work*. Columbia: Columbia University Press.
- Fraser N and Gordon L (1994) A genealogy of dependency: tracing a key word of the U.S. welfare state. *Signs* 19(2): 309–336.
- Funes Y (2022) Yes, colonialism caused climate change, IPCC reports. *The Frontline*. <https://atmos.earth/ipcc-report-colonialism-climate-change/>.
- Ghosh A (2021) *The Nutmeg's Curse*. Chicago: The University of Chicago Press.
- Gorbis M (2019) Five principles for thinking like a futurist. *Educause Review*, Winter 2019: 29–35.
- Gross LW (2016) *Anishinaabe ways of knowing and being*. Routledge.
- Guterres A (2020) Finance in common summit, Paris peace forum. <https://webtv.un.org/watch/ant%C3%B3nio-guterres-un-secretary-general-at-the-finance-in-common-summit-paris-peace-forum/6209374192001/>.
- Hart MA (2009) Anti-colonial indigenous social work: reflections on an aboriginal approach. In: Bruyere G, Hart MA and Sinclair R (eds) *Wicihitowin: Aboriginal Social Work in Canada*. Victoria: Fernwood Pub, 25–41.
- Hill L and Artiga S (2022) COVID-19 cases and deaths by race/ethnicity: current data and changes over time. *Kaiser Family Foundation* 22. <https://www.kff.org/racial-equity-and-health-policy/issue-brief/covid-19-cases-and-deaths-by-race-ethnicity-current-data-and-changes-over-time/>.
- Hirvilammi T and Koch M (2020) Sustainable welfare beyond growth. *Sustainability* 12(5): 1824–1832.
- Holmgren D (2009) *Future Scenarios*. Vermont: Chelsea Green Publishing.
- Horton R (2021) Climate and COVID-19: converging crises. *The Lancet* 397(10269): 71.
- IPCC (2022) Summary for policymakers. In: Pörtner H-O, Roberts DC, Tignor M, et al. (eds) *Climate Change 2022: Impacts, Adaptation, and Vulnerability*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press. DOI: [10.1017/9781009325844.001](https://doi.org/10.1017/9781009325844.001).
- Izlar J (2019) Radical social welfare and anti-authoritarian mutual aid. *Critical and Radical Social Work* 7(3): 349–366.
- Jacobson M (2007) Food matters: community food assessments as a tool for change. *Journal of Community Practice* 15(3): 37–55.
- Kendi IX (2019) *How to be an Antiracist*. Fort Worth: One world.

- Kenkel DJ (2020) Social work in the face of collapse. *Critical and Radical Social Work* 8(2): 241–254.
- Kimmerer RW (2003) *Gathering Moss*. Corvallis: Oregon State University Press.
- Kimmerer RW (2013) *Braiding Sweetgrass*. Minneapolis: Milkweed Editions.
- Kivel P (2007) Social service or social change? In INCITE Women of Color Against Violence (Ed.), *The Revolution Will Not Be Funded*. South End Press.
- Krings A, Victor BG, Mathias J, et al. (2020) Environmental social work in the disciplinary literature, 1991–2015. *International Social Work* 63(3): 275–290.
- LaDuke W (No date) *Food is Medicine*. Honor the Earth & White Earth Land Recovery Project.
- LaDuke W (1999) *All Our Relations*. Chicago: Haymarket Books.
- Lakhani N (2021) Exclusive: Indigenous Americans dying from Covid at twice the rate of white Americans. *The Guardian*. <https://www.theguardian.com/us-news/2021/feb/04/native-americans-coronavirus-covid-death-rate>.
- Libal K, Tomczak SM, Spath R, et al. (2014) Hunger in a “land of plenty”: a renewed call for social work action. *Social work* 59(4): 366–369.
- Littman DM, Boyett M, Bender K, et al. (2021) Values and beliefs underlying mutual aid: an exploration of collective care during the COVID-19 pandemic. *Journal of the Society for Social Work and Research*. <https://www.journals.uchicago.edu/doi/pdf/10.1086/716884>.
- Littman DM, Morris K, Hostetter CR, et al. (2023) How do participants conceptualize mutual aid in the early months of the COVID-19 pandemic? A critical phenomenological analysis. *Journal of Community Practice* 31: 193–214. DOI: [10.1080/10705422.2023.2210136](https://doi.org/10.1080/10705422.2023.2210136).
- Maples S (Host) (2022) Self-determination Pt. 2 with Rosebud bear schneider [audio podcast episode]. In *Spirit Plate*. San Francisco: Whetstone Radio. <https://podcasts.apple.com/us/podcast/spirit-plate/id1606238592>.
- Maylea C (2020) The end of social work. *British Journal of Social Work* 51: 772–789. DOI: [10.1093/bjsw/bcaa203](https://doi.org/10.1093/bjsw/bcaa203).
- McCleary J and Simard E (2021) Honoring our ancestors: using reconciliatory pedagogy to dismantle White supremacy. *Advances in Social Work* 21(2-3): 259–273.
- McNabb D (2019) Decolonising social work education in Aotearoa New Zealand. *Advances in Social Work and Welfare Education* 21(1): 35–50.
- Meadows D (1999) Leverage points: Places to intervene in a system. *The Sustainability Institute*. https://donellameadows.org/wp-content/userfiles/Leverage_Points.pdf.
- Meadows D, Randers J and Meadows D (2004) *Limits to Growth: the 30-year Update*. Vermont: Chelsea Green Publishing.
- Moody K (2020) How “just-in-time” capitalism spread COVID-19: trade routes, transmission, and international solidarity. *Spectre*. <https://spectrejournal.com/how-just-in-time-capitalism-spread-covid-19>.
- Moore JW (2017) The Capitalocene, Part I: on the nature and origins of our ecological crisis. *Journal of Peasant Studies* 44(3): 594–630.
- Newell JP, Foster A, Borgman M, et al. (2022) Ecosystem services of urban agriculture and prospects for scaling up production: a study of Detroit. *Cities* 125: 103664. DOI: [10.1016/j.cities.2022.103664](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cities.2022.103664).

- Nissen L and Scheyett A (2022) Pandemics, economic systems, and the future of social work. *Social Work* 67(1): 5–7.
- Nowell C (2020) In the Navajo Nation, anarchism has Indigenous roots. *The Nation*. <https://www.thenation.com/article/activism/anarchism-navajo-aid/>.
- Nugent C (2021) Amsterdam is embracing a radical new economic theory to help save the environment. Could it also replace capitalism? *Time*. <https://time.com/5930093/amsterdam-doughnut-economics/>.
- Osaka S (2020) Growing pains: post-COVID should countries rethink their obsession with economic growth? *Grist.org*. <https://grist.org/politics/post-covid-should-countries-rethink-their-obsession-with-economic-growth/>.
- Patel R (2009) Food sovereignty. *Journal of Peasant Studies* 36(3): 663–706.
- Polack R, Wood S and Bradley E (2008) Fossil fuels and food security: analysis and recommendations for community organizers. *Journal of Community Practice* 16(3): 359–375.
- Polanyi K (2001) *The Great Transformation*. Boston: Beacon Press.
- Powell C (2020) The color and gender of COVID-19: essential workers, not disposable people. *Think Global Health*. <https://www.thinkglobalhealth.org/article/color-and-gender-covid-19-essential-workers-not-disposable-people>.
- Powers MCF, Rambaree K and Peeters J (2019) Degrowth for transformational alternatives as radical social work practice. *Critical & Radical Social Work* 7(3): 417–433.
- Raekstad P (2018) Revolutionary practice and prefigurative politics: a clarification and defense. *Constellations* 25: 359–372.
- Ramsay S and Boddy J (2017) Environmental social work: a concept analysis. *British Journal of Social Work* 47(1): 68–86.
- Raworth K (2017) *Doughnut Economics*. Vermont: Chelsea Green Publishing.
- Reid-Merritt P (2010) *Righteous Self-Determination*. Orlando: Inprint Editions.
- Reisch M and Andrews J (2002) *The Road Not Taken*. Milton Park: Routledge.
- Richter K (2019) Struggling for another life: the ontology of degrowth. *Transtext(e)s Transcultures* 14: 1242. DOI: [10.4000/transtexts.1242](https://doi.org/10.4000/transtexts.1242).
- Roy A (2020) The pandemic is a portal. *Financial Times*. <https://www.ft.com/content/10d8f5e8-74eb-11ea-95fe-fcd274e920ca>.
- Samudzi Z and Anderson WC (2018) *As Black as Resistance*. California: A.K. Press.
- Simpson LR (2004) Anticolonial strategies for the recovery and maintenance of Indigenous knowledge. *American Indian Quarterly* 373–384.
- Sitrin M and Sembrar C (2020) *Pandemic Solidarity*. Chicago: Pluto Press.
- Smith LT (1999) *Decolonizing Methodologies*. London: Zed Books Ltd.
- Somers MR and Block F (2005) From poverty to perversity: ideas, markets, and institutions over 200 years of welfare debate. *American Sociological Review* 70(2): 260–287.
- Spade D (2020) Solidarity not charity: Mutual aid for mobilization and survival. *Social Text* 38(1): 131–151.
- Táíwò OO (2022) *Reconsidering Reparations*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Thompson EP (2001) The moral economy of the English crowd in the 18th century. In: Thompson D (ed) *The Essential E. P. Thompson*. New York: The New Press, 316–377.
- Turje M (2012) Social workers, farmers and food commodification: governmentality and neo-liberalism in the alternative food movement. *The Canadian Social Work Review* 29: 121–138.

- Whyte KP (2017) Indigenous climate change studies: indigenizing futures, decolonizing the Anthropocene. *English Language Notes* 55(1–2): 153–162. DOI: [10.1215/00138282-55.1-2.153](https://doi.org/10.1215/00138282-55.1-2.153).
- Wittman H, Desmarais A and Wiebe N (2010) The origins and potential of food sovereignty. In: Desmarais A, Wiebe N and Wittman H (eds) *Food Sovereignty: Reconnecting Food, Nature and Community*. Oakland: Food First Books, 1–14.
- Wright KC, Carr KA and Akin BA (2021) The whitewashing of social work history: how dismantling racism in social work education begins with an equitable history of the profession. *Advances in Social Work* 21(2-3): 274–297.